ian aid and building infrastructure. With Solih's term (2018-2023), India-Maldives ties and Indian investment in the nation reached a high, with Indian aid estimated to have crossed Rs 1,000 crore. In 2021, India extended a $50 million (Rs 416 crore) line of credit to the Maldives for defence projects.

Dr Harsh Pant, a senior research fellow at the Observer Research Foundation, believes that though Muizzu's recent statements are not surprising given his anti-India position, Indian presence in the country is minuscule and serves Maldivian security objectives.

Rear Admiral Sudarshan Shrikhande, former head of foreign cooperation, Indian Navy, says that Indian military personnel are engaged in a variety of tasks in coordination with the host (Maldivian) government. "Maldives has invited such cooperation and our small detachments are there in an open, transparent manner," he says.

Apprehensive about a greater Chinese role in the Maldives, Indian military planners have begun weighing their options for future moves. Vice Admiral Anil Kumar Chawla, former head of the Kochi-based southern naval command, says, "Maldives gets its entire maritime support from India. Now, the danger is that if India withdraws it and someone else takes over, the situation will not be in favour of New Delhi."

DEFENCE COOPERATION

The Maldives, known for its scenic beaches and holiday resorts, is one of the biggest beneficiaries of India's Neighbourhood First policy. Starting in 1988, defence cooperation between the two nations has expanded manifold. Male, aware of its limited capability to protect its Exclusive Economic Zone (EEZ)—the nearly 1 mn sq. km of sea over which it has sovereign rights—against smuggling, trafficking and piracy, looks to New Delhi for its security needs. During Nasheed's presidency, India and the Maldives signed a defence pact that paved the way for Indian aid—a military hospital, radars and the Dhruv helicopters. Even during the pro-China Yameen regime, defence ties progressed. For New Delhi, support for the Maldives has had an added objective—to keep Chinese influence at bay.

Besides providing military hardware and infrastructure, both nations engage in joint exercises, patrolling and surveillance of the Maldives' EEZ. India also provides medical training, disaster response assistance, help with search and rescue operations, hydrographic mapping and maritime domain awareness. In addition, it provides trained pilots, observers and engineers to operate the Dornier aircraft it has given the Maldives for surveillance.

Starting from 2007, India has installed 10 coastal surveillance radars across the islands; the Extended Coastal Surveillance Radar System (CSRS) will integrate the information from these radars. The system was built with an Indian grant of $15.8 million (Rs 131 crore). The CSRS data will feed into India's International Fusion Centre and will be linked to similar systems set up in Sri Lanka, Mauritius and Seychelles.



"Maldives gets its entire maritime support from India. If India withdraws it and if someone else takes over, it will not be in favour of New Delhi"

Vice Admiral Anil Kumar Chawla
Former commander-in-chief, Southern Naval Command

External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar, who visited the Maldives to hand over the CSRS in 2022, had said that it will contribute to enhancing the security for the entire region and was an example of India's 'SAGAR' (Security and Growth for All in the Region) and Neighbourhood First policies.

In May 2023, defence minister

INDIA'S HELPI

OVER THE YEARS, INDIA HAS GIVEN BUILT DEFENCE AND CIVILIAN INFR HUMANITARIAN ASSISTANCE



DEFENCE ASSETS

DHRUV HELICOPTERS 2
Delivered: 2010-2013

- Maintained and operated by Indian personnel, the helicopters are used for surveillance and medical evacuation

DORNIER AIRCRAFT 1
Delivered: September 2020

- Also maintained by India, it patrols the Maldives' 1 million sq. km EEZ for anti-trafficking, anti-piracy, search & rescue operations

FAST INTERCEPTOR BOAT 1
Delivered: December 2019

- Named Coast Guard Ship *Kaamiyaabu*, it enhances Maldives' maritime security, safeguards its tourism industry

SEA AMBULANCES 2
Delivered: January 2023

- Part of an assistance of $400,000 (Rs 3.33 cr), they strengthen the healthcare system